Study Sheet: Understanding Setting

What is Setting?

Setting is the time, place, and environment in which a story occurs. It includes not only physical location and historical period, but also social context, weather, and atmosphere.

Functions of Setting

- Establishes time and place of the story.
- Creates mood or atmosphere.
- Can symbolize or foreshadow events.
- Helps reveal character traits by reflecting emotions or conflicts.
- Supports the themes of the story.

Examples from Texts

Kate Chopin's 'The Story of an Hour'
- Mrs. Mallard sits by an open window. She sees blue sky, hears sparrows, and smells rain. These natural images reflect her shift from grief to freedom and symbolize rebirth.

Daphne du Maurier's 'Rebecca'
- The overgrown garden at Manderley and the menacing rhododendrons symbolize Rebecca's lingering power and the narrator's feelings of fear and insecurity. The setting mirrors her sense of being overshadowed.

Tips for Analyzing Setting

- Look for natural imagery (weather, seasons, plants) and ask what emotions they reflect.
- Notice contrasts in setting (dark vs. light, order vs. decay) and connect them to themes.
- Ask: How does the place make the character feel? Safe, trapped, free, fearful?
- Consider whether the setting changes as the character changes.

Practice Questions

- How does the open window in 'The Story of an Hour' symbolize Mrs. Mallard's emotions?
- In 'Rebecca,' what does the menacing description of the garden reveal about the narrator's state of mind?
- Think of another story or novel you've read. How does the setting reveal something important about the character?